
Paper 3, Option 38.1:

The making of modern Russia, 1855–1991

Overview

This option comprises two parts: the *Aspects in breadth* focus on long-term changes and contextualise the *Aspects in depth*, which focus in detail on key episodes.

Together, the breadth and depth topics explore how Russia has developed, socially, politically and economically, through a turbulent era marked by periods of stability, reform and revolution. The death of Nicholas I in 1855 ushered in a period of hope and reform under his son Alexander II. Subsequently, more violent and dramatic changes in the twentieth century turned the lives of ordinary Russians upside down.

Aspects in breadth: the land and the peasantry, 1855–1991	
Themes	Content
1 The changing status and condition of the peasantry	• The impact of changes in government policy, 1855–1991 (key developments: the abolition of serfdom 1861, Stolypin's reforms 1906–11, the Land Decree 1917, NEP 1921, collectivisation 1928–32, the increase in state farms (<i>sovkhoz</i>) at the expense of <i>kolkhoz</i> after 1945). • Living standards and leaving the land, 1855–1991: the burden of redemption payments and overpopulation, periods of famine, migration and prosperity (key developments: the concession of peasant plots 1932, reduction of taxes on private plots and peasant households 1953–54).
2 Agriculture and productivity: meeting the country's needs?	• Reform, innovation and productivity, 1861–1991: the backwardness of peasant agriculture in the nineteenth century (key developments: the impact of railways on the larger estates of the gentry and nobility pre-1914, the drive to modernise under Stalin, Khrushchev's drive to boost productivity – maize mania and the Virgin Lands, attempts to boost productivity under Brezhnev and Gorbachev). • Feeding the population, 1861–1991: the extent to which agriculture met the changing demands to feed the populace of countryside and town (key development: the import of western grain, 1972–79).

Aspects in depth: reform and revolution	
Key topics	Content
1 The political reforms of Alexander II, 1855–70	• The impact of the Crimean War; impetus to reform; army reforms, including to training, weapons, promotions, the period of conscription and to military bureaucracy. • Reform of the legal system and its significance; the reform of local government: the <i>zemstvo</i> statute of 1864, the work and importance of the <i>zemstvos</i>; the municipal statute of 1870. • The extent of greater freedom of expression; the significance of the university statute 1863; the significance of new press regulations 1865.
2 Revolution and reform, 1904–06	• The impact of the Russo-Japanese war as a stimulus to reform and revolution. • The significance of Bloody Sunday 1905: strikes and mutinies; formation and impact of the Union of Unions. The significance of the October Manifesto: extent of concessions. • Repression of opposition in town and countryside, including the closure of the St Petersburg and Moscow Soviets.
3 The end of the Romanovs and the triumph of the Bolsheviks, 1916–18	• Impact of defeat and suffering, 1916–17; the murder of Rasputin; reasons, events and significance of the February Revolution; the end of Tsardom, the Provisional government and relations with the Petrograd Soviet. • The reasons for the October Revolution: the importance of the Petrograd Soviet, Lenin and Trotsky; the difficulties of, and mistakes made by, the Provisional government. • The Bolsheviks in power, 1917–18: concessions and violence; dissolving the Constituent Assembly and setting up the Cheka and the Red Army; making peace with Germany.
4 Khrushchev and attempts to reform the Soviet system, 1956–61	• The impetus to reform: Khrushchev's personality and aims; his championing of the Party over bureaucratic conservatism; discontent in the camps and the release of prisoners. • De-Stalinisation: the speech to the Twentieth Party Congress 1956; resistance in the party, including Molotov in 1957. • Administrative reforms: decentralisation; the restructuring of the security apparatus. Extent of new intellectual and cultural freedom, and limitations, including the closure of churches.
5 Gorbachev and the downfall of Soviet communism, 1985–91	• The impetus to reform: impact of Afghanistan war; economic stagnation; the alcohol problem; rising nationalism; impact of Chernobyl; Gorbachev's personality and ideas. • Impacts of <i>glasnost</i> and <i>perestroika</i>: treatment of dissidents, including Sakharov; new appointments, including Yeltsin; attempts at administrative reform and to tackle alcoholism. • Divisions in the reformist camp, conservative opposition; growing rivalry with Yeltsin; the conservatives' attempted coup; the downfall of Communist Party rule.